

Practice Paper 38 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “A floor that did not yet exist”

1 mark for understanding that the floor was **still under construction** / **unfinished**; **1 mark** for explaining the **paradox**: although the concrete slab was physically present, the floor lacked the **walls, windows and ceiling** that would normally make a “floor” a complete and enclosed space.

Sample answer: He means that although the concrete had already been poured, the level was **not yet a proper floor** in the usual sense, because it had **no walls, no windows and no ceiling** — only open sky around it.

Q2. [2] — Effect of the word **persuade**

1 mark — **Persuade** is a word normally used of **people**, suggesting that the narrator treats the coupling as if it had a **mind of its own**.

1 mark — It suggests his attitude is **patient, respectful** and **almost affectionate**: he sees his work as a **negotiation** with materials rather than a fight with them. (Also accept: it shows **expertise** — the job requires skill and care, not force.)

Q3. [2] — Attitude to safety

1 mark — He is **careful and methodical** (checking the harness **twice**).

1 mark — His safety habits come from a **respect for his father’s experience** and an awareness that careful checking is precisely what **kept his father alive** through forty years of dangerous work. (Also accept: a **family tradition** / **inherited discipline** of safety.)

Q4. [2] — Two details that show the silence is not absolute

1 mark each for any two of:

- The “**soft tick of cooling steel**”.
- The “**whine of a distant grinder**”.

- The “**periodic ping of the radio at [his] hip**”.

Reject: “the horns and the brakes and the chatter” — these are described as **filtered out**, not present.

Q5. [2] — “A thing you watch rather than a thing that watches you”

1 mark — At ground level, the city **surrounds** him and presses in on him with its noise, traffic and crowds — it makes demands on his attention.

1 mark — From above, the city is **distant and quiet**, a passive **scene to be observed**; he is **outside** it rather than inside it, and the usual pressures of being **seen** and **jostled** fall away.

Q6. [2] — Pipes “disagreed about how tightly they wished to be married”

1 mark — The pipes are **personified** — given the human qualities of **disagreement** and **marriage**.

1 mark — The image is **gently humorous**: it makes a dry technical fault sound like a domestic squabble, and shows the narrator’s **affectionate familiarity** with the materials of his trade. (Also accept: it makes the writing **vivid** and the narrator’s voice **warm**.)

Q7. [3] — Vertigo, sudden and disorientating (language question)

1 mark for identifying the **sudden shift / loss of equilibrium**; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “**my inner ear... remembered the truth**” — personifies the inner ear as if it had been **kindly lying to him**, emphasising how abruptly the illusion of safety collapses.
- “**The floor tilted, although it had not moved**” — the **contradiction** between perception and reality conveys **disorientation**.
- “**My hands knew, before my head did**” — his body reacts **faster than his mind**, suggesting **instinct under shock**.
- “**a man on a small concrete raft**” — the metaphor reduces the huge building to a **tiny, precarious vessel**, making him feel **adrift and exposed**.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q8. [1] — “The whole secret payment of skilled work”

1 mark: The word **secret** suggests the **real reward** is **private / invisible to outsiders** — it is the **personal pride and satisfaction** known only to the worker, not the wage or the praise that others might give. (Also accept: it suggests skilled labour is **undervalued** by the public.)

Q9. [1] — Evidence of personal connection to the city

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- He can see “**the three estates my father had helped to raise in the 1970s**”.
- He can see “**the school my daughter would walk to next year**”.
- He can see “**the long curve of the expressway that I had laid kerb-stones along as an apprentice**”.
- The city is “**a map of the hours of my own life**”.

Q10. [2] — Builders “know” the city “better than most”

1 mark — He wants the reader to see builders as **insiders** / **intimately familiar** with the city, not as **outsiders** or **strangers** to it.

1 mark — He wishes to **challenge a common assumption** that workmen are **removed from** or **anonymous to** the places they build — in fact they have a **deeper, lived knowledge** of those places than most residents. (Also accept: a plea for the **dignity** / **recognition** of skilled labour.)

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **quietly proud, humble, reflective, dignified, contented**. (Reject: **boastful, sad** — these miss the modest, satisfied quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — Writer’s attitude (future of food vs. expensive salad)

1 mark — The contrast shows that the writer is **balanced** / **undecided** / **not fully committed** to either view.

1 mark — He acknowledges the **genuine potential** of vertical farms while also recognising their **absurdly high costs** — his attitude is **sceptical but open-minded**. (Also accept: **wryly amused, measured**.)

Q13. [2] — Advantages of vertical farming

1 mark each for any two of:

- Crops can be harvested **all year round**, unaffected by **weather**.
- **Almost no pesticides** are needed because pests are kept out.
- **Very large water savings** — about **five litres** per head of lettuce instead of **two hundred and fifty**.
- The farms can be located **in cities**, close to where the food is eaten.

Q14. [2] — Why water savings matter in Southeast Asia

1 mark — **Land is scarce** in the region, so traditional large-scale farming is difficult.

1 mark — **Rainfall is becoming more unreliable** / **erratic** due to climate change, making **water-efficient** methods especially valuable.

Q15. [2] — Effect of “stubbornly”

1 mark — **Stubbornly** personifies the **economics**, as if the numbers themselves were **refusing to cooperate** with the optimistic story of vertical farming.

1 mark — It emphasises that the financial problems are **persistent** and **unresolved despite years of effort** — they cannot be easily argued or wished away.

Q16. [2] — Garnish vs dinner (own words)

1 mark — Vertical farms can produce **small, decorative crops** — **herbs and leaves** — that **flavour or accompany** a meal.

1 mark — They **cannot, at present, grow staple foods** — **rice, wheat or potatoes** — that **make up the main, filling part** of what most people actually eat.

Reject answers that lift “supply your dinner” without rewording.

Q17. [2] — “Equally fairly”

1 mark — It signals that **both sides** of the argument — defenders **and** critics — have **legitimate points**; the writer is **not taking sides**.

1 mark — It reinforces the writer’s **even-handed** / **balanced** approach, showing that the debate cannot be resolved by dismissing either view as foolish.

Q18. [2] — Lesson from the pandemic (own words)

1 mark — Cities heavily **dependent on imported food** discovered that **international supply chains** are **fragile** / **can be disrupted** by global crises.

1 mark — As a result, **some local production capacity** is needed as a **backup** / **safeguard** to keep **essential institutions** (school and hospital kitchens) running when borders close.

Q19. [2] — Why traditional farmers are sceptical

1 mark each for any two of:

- Vertical farms depend entirely on **constant electricity**, **air conditioning** and **computerised systems** — a **power cut** can destroy a whole crop.
- The **proprietary nutrient mixes** and complex technology make them **less resilient**, not more, than ordinary farms.
- The idea of **soilless agriculture** has been **promoted as a revolution before** and has **repeatedly failed** once funding dried up.

Q20. [1] — Tone of “some truth in this, even if it is not the whole truth”

1 mark — Any **one** of: **measured**, **judicious**, **balanced**, **fair-minded**, **conciliatory**. (Reject: **dismissive**, **sarcastic**.)

Q21. [2] — Effect of “portfolio”

1 mark — **Portfolio** is a **financial** / **investment** metaphor: it suggests a **mix** of different assets, none of which carries all the risk.

1 mark — Applied to food, it implies that **food security** should rest on **several complementary methods** — vertical farms, soil farming, imports — rather than on **one single solution**; it makes vertical farms sound **useful but partial**.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Advantages of vertical urban farms (Paragraphs 2 and 5):

1. **Year-round harvests**, unaffected by weather such as drought or monsoon.
2. **Near-zero pesticide use**, because pests are excluded from sealed indoor spaces.
3. **Dramatically lower water consumption** through recirculating hydroponic / aeroponic systems.
4. They **strengthen food security** / provide a **local backup** when long supply chains are disrupted.

Difficulties / disadvantages (Paragraphs 3, 4 and 6):

5. **Very high electricity costs** from continuous lighting and air conditioning, which several operators have not been able to recover.
6. They can only profitably grow a **narrow range of crops** — salad leaves and herbs — **not staples** such as rice or wheat.
7. The produce is **significantly more expensive** than soil-grown equivalents, putting it out of reach of most shoppers.

8. They are **fragile** — dependent on continuous power and technology — and a brief **outage** can ruin an entire crop.

Sample full-marks summary (79 words):

Vertical urban farms offer several advantages, including harvests every day of the year regardless of weather, almost no use of pesticides, and dramatic water savings. They also strengthen local food security when overseas supply chains falter. However, they remain financially fragile: electricity bills are enormous, only a narrow set of leafy crops is profitable, and the produce is priced well above soil-grown alternatives. They are also vulnerable, since a brief power failure can wipe out an entire crop.

Length count: 79 words from “Vertical” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —